

Eastside Preparatory School's Community Briefings

On Monday, March 2nd, the school announced that it would be moving from in-person to online instruction to slow the spread of Covid-19 also known as Coronavirus. Below is the series of communications sent to the community to keep them informed.

The shift in school modality and the community concerns surrounding the spread of the virus places a large emotional and cognitive load on everyone involved. While the school is not in a crisis, many of the best practices in crisis management have been employed below.

Critical Components

- State your communications cadence and then meet that expectation. Knowing that there will be an update every day at 5pm is calming (as long as you continue to meet that expectation)
- Make sure each briefing is accurate and does not contain any language that might have to be walked back. If you are not 100% sure on a decision, it belongs in the next briefing.
- Have a separate briefing for your employees and your students/parent community. This allows you to write to your audience, including operational details for your faculty that would only add confusion to the parent community.

Early informative messages – before the decision to move to online instruction:

1/27/2020 SUBJECT: Information for the EPS Community

Message

from the Head of School

Dear EPS Families, Trustees, Faculty, and Staff:

We are sure you have been monitoring the news about the novel coronavirus. Our responsibility as a school is to establish protocols that safeguard our community and contribute to preventing the possible spread of the virus. This communication

is intended to provide recommendation to protect the health of the community.

The fact that this is a new version of a known type of virus requires a higher level of caution until more can be understood. Health officials have recently reported that carriers may be contagious before any signs or symptoms are present. As this is a rapidly evolving situation that the Center for Disease Control and Prevention is still researching, and because this virus emerged in China, the school is recommending the following:

1. If families have had, or currently have, visitors from China, students should have their temperature monitored twice daily at home.
2. If members of your family have recently been in an airport, students should also have their temperature monitored twice daily at home.
3. If any signs or symptoms are present or develop, students should be checked by a doctor. These symptoms include:
 - runny nose
 - headache
 - cough
 - sore throat
 - fever (over 100)
 - a general feeling of being unwell

General Precautionary Measures

If your student is showing any signs of cold-like symptoms as noted above, keep them home. Work can be made up when students are healthy.

We also recommend that every member of the community take the following steps:

1. Do not come to school if you exhibit any symptoms noted above
2. Frequently wash hands with soap for 20 seconds or longer
3. Report any symptoms such as cough, fever, aches
4. Cough into your sleeve
5. Avoid touching your eyes or mouth before washing hands
6. Be sure to wash or gel hands before eating

If you have any questions or concerns about symptoms experienced now or in the last month, please see your health care provider. We have previously communicated these expectations to students at the start of flu season and will remind them in the coming days in the context of this new health concern.

As the situation develops, we will keep you informed of anything we learn that might be helpful to the community. In the meantime, we ask that everyone take appropriate precautions.

Sincerely,

Terry Macaluso, PhD
Head of School

2/21/2020 SUBJECT: EPS Welcome Back and Health Precautions

Message
from the Head of School

Dear Families --

Welcome back from February break! I trust that vacations were restful, and that adventures were memorable.

I'm writing to you today so that everyone is fully aware of the obligation each of us carries regarding the spread of coronavirus, now identified as **COVID-19**.

The Center for Disease Control and Washington State Department of Health provide detailed information on the risks of being exposed to COVID-19 and general precautions to take regarding COVID-19, with recommendations specific to Washington students who may have recently traveled to China. Please refer to the following links:

- <https://www.cdc.gov/coronavirus/2019-ncov/index.html>
- <https://www.cdc.gov/coronavirus/2019-ncov/travelers/faqs.html>
- <https://www.doh.wa.gov/Emergencies/Coronavirus/Schools>.

In addition, we ask that everyone review the recommendations outlined in my previous email (<link>) regarding families that have traveled over break.

We ask all families and employees to take the steps they consider appropriate inasmuch as we all share responsibility for the health of our community.

Thank you in advance for your careful consideration,

Terry Macaluso, PhD
Head of School

2/27/2020 SUBJECT: EPS Prevention and Planning Related to COVID-19

Message

from the Head of School

Dear Families—

I trust that you, along with the rest of the nation, are watching closing the daily developments of the COVID-19 virus. While the immediate effect in the U.S. is relatively low at this time, in an overabundance of caution for the safety of our students and staff we are taking steps to minimize the possibility of any impact. I want to let you know of the steps we have taken, and those we are prepared to take to ensure the health and safety of our students, families and employees.

Prevention

The recommendations and guidelines for the prevention of spread of COVID-19 are the same as for other contagious diseases:

- Students and employees should remain at home if feeling unwell.
- Regular hand washing and/or the use of hand sanitizers with 60%+ alcohol are recommended.
- Each EPS class and meeting room has been equipped with sanitizing wipes and hand gel. Faculty will ask students to wipe down their classroom areas at the beginning of each class period.
- Our facilities staff continues to work diligently to clean all common areas of our buildings.
- The CDC has recommendations for reducing the spread of COVID-19 that can be found here (<https://www.cdc.gov/coronavirus/2019-ncov/about/steps-when-sick.html>). While we have no reason to suspect that anyone in our community has been exposed to the virus, the link contains good advice for all.

Planning Considerations

Last week we made the unprecedented decision to cancel our EBC Week trips to both Japan and Italy based on the situation in those countries and recommendations by the CDC that travel to those destinations had reached Level 2 on the warning scale. We will continue to monitor this evolving situation and will make decisions regarding other trips in the coming days.

In addition, we are putting protocols in place if we cannot gather on campus (for whatever reason). We are designing a plan that would allow us to teach using Microsoft Teams and Canvas. We've asked faculty members to think about how they would teach their classes using those tools and we are planning to run a drill for A, B and C periods on Friday, March 6th. Our request to you is that you have your child(ren) at their laptops and ready to test the plan. We'll conduct classes for blocks A, B, and C, beginning at 10:00am, and concluding at 11:30am. More detailed instructions will accompany the reminder about the March 6 systems test.

In order to prepare students for this eventuality, time will be set aside in Advisory next week to ensure that all students are able to access and use Teams. We'll learn more once we've completed our drill on March 6th—and will provide any information necessary to parents to be ready in the event that school will not be meeting on campus.

Rest assured that we will continue to monitor developments closely. We are checking the most recent recommendation and news from multiple sources—CDC, WHO, NAIS and local public health officials. We will provide any additional updates as it relates to our school and our greater community, as they are available.

Thank you in advance for your careful consideration,

Terry Macaluso, PhD
Head of School

Message indicating the shift to online education

3/2/2020 SUBJECT: EPS: Update on EPS Campus

Message

from the Head of School

Dear EPS community members—

In the past few days I have emailed you several times to let you know of the precautions and preparations we have been taking at Eastside Prep regarding COVID-19. Today finds us at a crossroads with more cases being reported and a likely expectation of more to come.

While we have no known or suspected cases of the virus in our community, I do not feel it is prudent to wait until there is a known case to take action. To that end, I have decided to implement our distance learning program for the next several weeks. This is a preventative measure aimed at prioritizing the health and safety of our community members. We have focused on technological tools that enhance our teaching for years, and we are perfectly positioned to change the modality through which we teach while continuing to deliver the excellent education for which Eastside Prep is known.

Here are some important details:

There will be no classes held on campus or online tomorrow, Tuesday, March 3rd, as faculty prepare to finish the current trimester and begin the new trimester online.

Schedule for the rest of the week:

Tuesday, 3/3	No classes; faculty prepare for online instruction. <i>Students should be working through their end-of-term assessments for trimester-long classes, which remain due on Thursday, March 5.</i>
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Wednesday, 3/4	No classes; faculty prepare for online instruction. Students should be working through their end-of-term assessments for trimester-long classes, which remain due on Thursday, March 5.
Thursday, 3/5	No classes; faculty prepare for online instruction. Students should be working through their end-of-term assessments for trimester-long classes, which remain due on Thursday, March 5. Teachers may be in communication with students as second trimester assessments are completed. Students should check Canvas regularly according to their classes for trimester 2.
Friday, 3/6	Faculty will lead students in trial runs using Canvas and/or Microsoft Teams according to the schedule below for <i>only the three class periods listed</i>. Students should follow their <i>third trimester</i> schedules. Instructions on how to sign in will be available by end of day on Thursday. • 10:00am – 10:25am – A Block convenes online • 10:30am – 10:55am – B Block convenes on line • 11:00am – 11:25am – C Block convenes on line
Monday, 3/9	Regular Schedule A – D
Tuesday, 3/10	Regular Schedule E – H

Other Important Details

- We expect to be able to reconvene classes on campus on Monday, April 13th.
- Students should prepare to access all school-related activities (classes, advisory, seminars, etc.) online through Canvas and Teams.
- All activities related to EBC Week are cancelled and classes (online or otherwise) will not be held during that time (essentially creating a two-week spring break: March 30-April 10).
- If parents had social gatherings for students planned in the upcoming weeks, we strongly advise that those activities be postponed. All previously scheduled activities (e.g. Sophomore Parent Night, EBC Night) outside the school day are postponed indefinitely.
- Athletics and the all-school musical are postponed until April 13th.

This decision is one of the hardest I have ever made; it may well be one of the most difficult school-related situations your family has had to accommodate. The health and safety of families and employees is paramount. Also of critical importance is the completion of this academic year. We have prepared for years for this kind of experience. Our faculty and students are facile with technology and we are utterly up to the challenge. Thank you in advance for your support and encouragement. I will be in regular (at least weekly) contact as we proceed through the coming weeks.

Kind regards,

Terry Macaluso, PhD
Head of School

DAILY BRIEFINGS (All subjects EPS Community Briefing: [date])

Message

from the Head of School

Community Briefing: March 3, 2020

A briefing will be sent to the entire community every school day at this time.

Setting Up for Success

Online instruction is different than on campus instruction, and it requires a different mindset as well as some changes to your standard daily practices. While each individual

student will have to decide what works best for them, the following tips will provide some basic suggestions on setting up for success while engaged in online instruction:

- Find a consistent place to engage in schoolwork. Somewhere that is quiet, free from distractions, and consistently available to you.
- Make a commitment to avoid social media and other online distractions during school hours. This is your education and it will require your engagement to get the most out of each online course experience.
- Engage actively in the content—this is not a vacation; school will continue as scheduled and it will require your full attention.
- For all the benefits of this online instructional model, it also has some challenges. There may be frustration if the technology doesn't work seamlessly. It may be hard for some to stay focused. Some may feel lonely or isolated. Be aware of what is working well and what isn't. Stay in close communication with your teachers about challenges you experience. Take note of your own feelings. This is a community-wide experience, so let's work together to make it as productive and pleasant as possible. We are all learning through this process, so let's embrace the challenge, support each other, and stay positive.
- Take breaks, practice mindfulness, and pace yourself. Take a break from your computer screen. Go outside, take a short walk, and get some fresh air during breaks you would normally have in your school day. Take a lunch break and eat a healthy lunch. There is a lot of important school work that needs to take place in the coming weeks, but that does not mean you shouldn't pause to engage in healthy self-care activities throughout the day.
- Learn from each other. Talk to family members, classmates, and others who have worked from home in the past to learn what worked for them. Share your own experiences with others.
- Don't go it alone. Keep lines of communication open with your teachers and your advisor. Setup online study groups with classmates. Reach out for help, advice, and encouragement when you need it. If you need extra academic support, contact your advisor. If you need additional emotional support, contact one of our school counselors.

- Keep your equipment working. If you're having difficulties with your computer, e-mail <tech email address> for assistance.
- EPS Counselors are available at <counselor email address> or <counselor 2 email address>.

Calendar Change: **Friday, March 27**

March 27, 2020—formerly a PDD, will now be a regular class day.

Schedule:

Time	Period
7:00 - 7:50	Zero period
8:00 - 8:40	A period
8:50 - 9:30	B period
9:40 - 10:20	C period
10:30 - 11:10	D period
11:15 - 11:45	US Advisory and US Advisory Meetings
11:45 - 12:20	Lunch Break
12:20 - 1:00	E period
1:20 - 1:50	F period
2:00 - 2:40	G period
2:50 - 3:30	H period

This is the last day before spring break, so this is a reasonable time to close out whatever is appropriately completed and position students to begin a new module on April 13, when we're back on campus.

Minimum Hours of Instruction: **STATE REQUIREMENT**

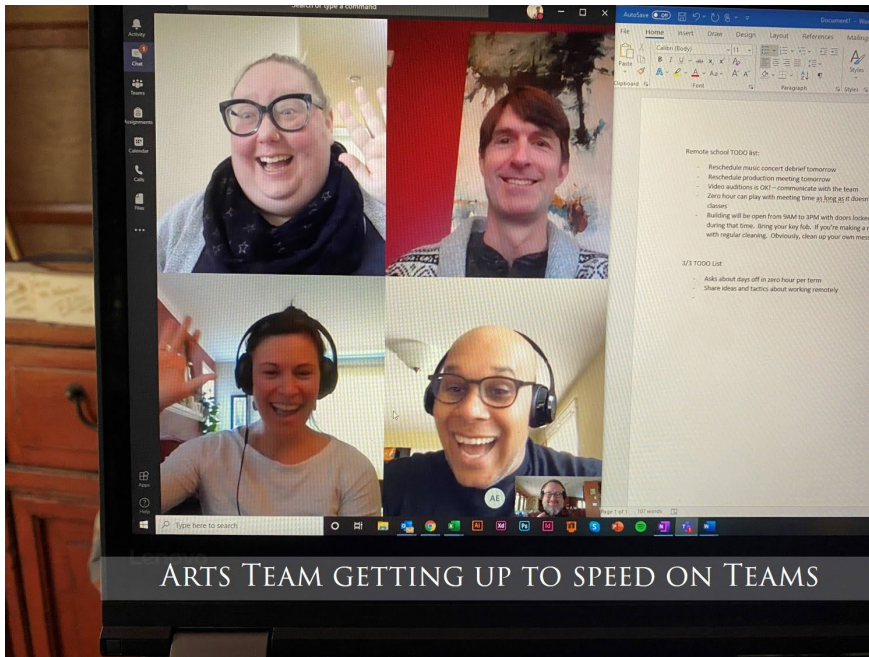
Including all changes during this transition week, snow days, and the cancellation, EPS will complete the academic year with at least 70 hours of instruction beyond the state requirement.

Advisory Sessions

Students will have weekly meetings as regularly scheduled on Mondays. In addition, advisors will have a weekly check-in with each advisee. Please contact advisors for schedule changes and any other individual matters to be considered.

Other Item/s to Note:

Middle School Study Halls will not meet via teams while we are conducting school online. Study Hall will resume when we are back on campus.



Message

from the Head of School

Community Briefing: March 4, 2020

A briefing will be sent to the entire community every school day at this time.

Friday, March 6

On Friday, if students are available, we will be running practice classes. Here is the schedule:

- A Block: 10:00 – 10:25am
- B Block: 10:30 – 10:55am
- C Block: 11:00 – 11:25am

Students will find their invitation in their Outlook and Teams calendars. Detailed instructions will be sent to students by their division head tomorrow, March 5.

EBC Funds

As a reminder, all EBC experiences have been cancelled. EPS is working with our travel partners to obtain refunds for the EBC trips. We hope to receive refunds for amounts our partners have not already expended on our behalf. We expect to have all the information by the end of March. You may send a message to Casey Otley, EPS CFO, at <business office email> if you have specific questions. We will communicate to families as soon as we have the necessary information from our travel partners.

Counseling Services

We recognize that there will be a wide range of thoughts, feelings, and responses that arise as COVID-19 impacts our greater community and as EPS has made the precautionary decision to transition to remote learning. Students may experience increased anxiousness, fear, and/or feel the impact of social disconnectedness. Remaining informed of the facts, innovating means to maintain connectedness with peers, and practicing healthy hygiene habits are just a few of the ways students can preserve their well-being.

If feelings become overwhelming, please know that students can access their EPS School Counselors via email: [list of counselors and emails].

We will do our best to validate student experience and provide them with strategies or resources to support. Expect a response within 24 hours, in which we can offer written feedback or the option to set up individual appointments to video chat via Microsoft Teams during standard school hours.

In a case of a mental health crisis, we ask that you reach out to local or national resources if you or someone you know is experiencing difficulties:

- King County 24-Hour Crisis Line: 1-866-427-4747
- National Suicide Prevention Lifeline: 1-800-273-8255
- 24/7 Crisis Text Line: 741741
- The Trevor Project: 1-866-488-7386

Attendance Reminder

Teachers will still check attendance during online class sessions. Parents/guardians are requested to call the attendance line or email (<attendance email>) if your student is not be able to participate in the online classes. If your student is sick, please provide brief details of symptoms.

Calendar Change: Friday, March 27

March 27, 2020—formerly a PDD, will now be a regular class day. **Classes will still be taught online.**

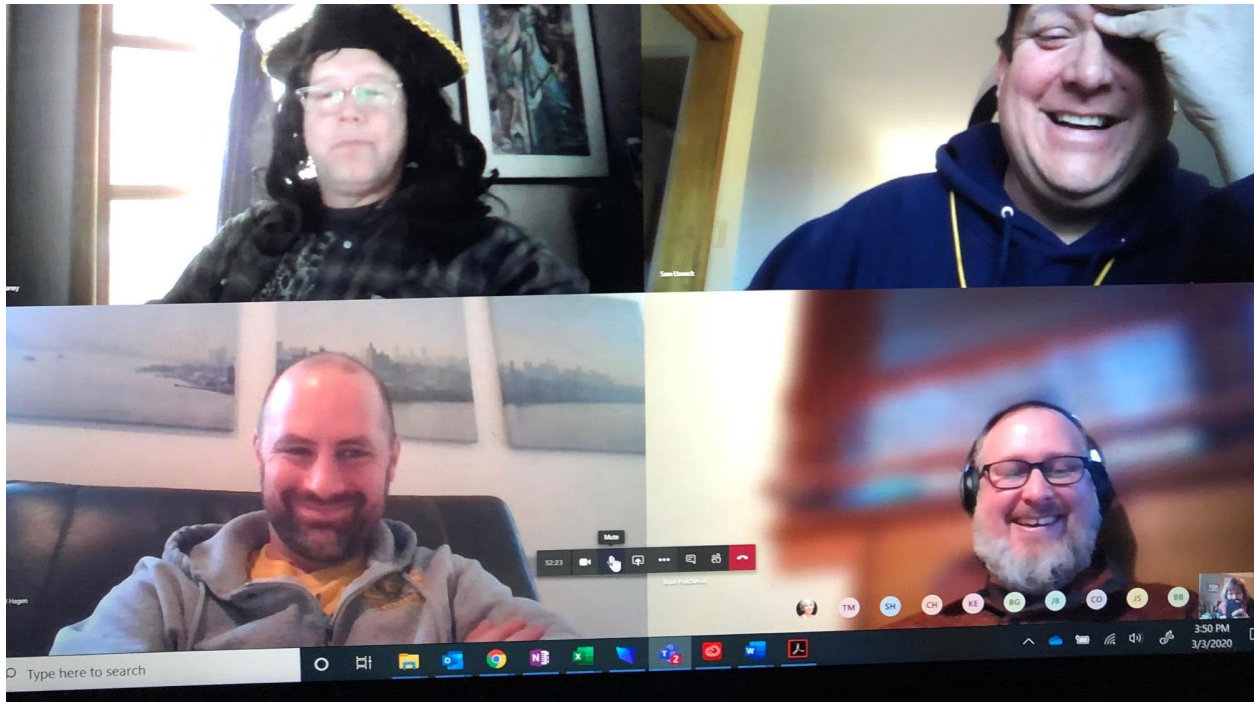
Schedule:

Time	Period
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9:40 - 10:20	C period
10:30 - 11:10	D period
11:15 - 11:45	US Advisory and MS Advisory
11:45 - 12:20	Lunch Break
12:20 - 1:00	E period
1:10 - 1:50	F period
2:00 - 2:40	G period
2:50 - 3:30	H period

This is the last day before spring break, so this is a reasonable time to close out whatever is appropriately completed and position students to begin a new module on April 13, when we're back on campus.

Faculty Meeting

We started the day today with over 70 people meeting online. Faculty broke into small groups to discuss effective ways to teach their classes online. Questions were answered by representatives of Microsoft Education—a group we have been working with for several years.



[If images are not properly displayed, click here to view this email in your browser](#)

Message

from the Head of School

Community Briefing: March 5, 2020

A briefing will be sent to the entire community every school day at this time.

Reminder that we will be running practice classes tomorrow, Friday, March 6.

- A Block: 10:00 – 10:25 AM
- B Block: 10:30 – 10:55 AM
- C Block: 11:00 – 11:25 AM

Students will find their invitation in their Outlook and Teams calendars. Detailed instructions were sent to students by their division head today, March 5.

Please don't record classes.

We are asking that online classes not be recorded for these reasons:

- Recording class information might encourage students to take latitude in terms of class attendance. If they think they can have class at a time of their own choosing, we will quickly lose any sense of shared experience that we're trying to create.
- We want students to feel free to engage by asking questions. They may sensor themselves if they know they are being recorded.
- And finally, recording classes has not been the norm at EPS; we want to treat these online classes just like our regular classes.

Impact on Home Life and Potentially Blurred Boundaries

Since several parents are now being asked by their employers to work from home, we have now created small villages of people who are not used to spending the day together—and who are not used to doing what they do at work and at school—at home. People with children may be working at home while their children are attending school online, and with a partner who is also having to spend the work day at home.

These circumstances are untried and unpracticed. To help reduce stress consider these observations:

1. Students and adults need defined, separate, private work space.

2. Students need to be dressed as they would dress for school.
3. Parents are asked to allow students the privacy they enjoy when they are on campus.
4. Be mindful that whatever is designated as the work space will be on camera and visible to everyone in any session. Think about what is appropriate to share in terms of the interior of homes.
5. Focus on one class at a time—and one task at a time.
6. Check yourself and your emotional health; take breaks from the screen when you do not have to be present in a session.
7. Teaching and learning online is enervating. That stress added to the already occasional stress of home life relationships can, if we're not alert, have a debilitating impact on the whole family.
8. Practice being your most patient self. And then, push yourself to become more patient than that.
9. Remember—every day—to schedule time to move, to go for a walk, to work out, to have lunch, and to turn the screen off.

Additional Resources

- [Talking Tips: Corona Virus](#)
- ["Why Online Connection and Collaboration Matter, Now More Than Ever"](#)

Seen and Heard

"I miss school too :/ and am adjusting to doing everything online but I am also excited to

try this out! Its kinda exciting to have such a sudden change "

- 8th grader over email today

[If images are not properly displayed, click here to view this email in your browser](#)

Message

from the Head of School

Community Briefing: March 6, 2020

A briefing will be sent to the entire community every school day at this time.

Good Friday afternoon, everyone,

This is to report that at the end of the first 4 days as an online school, we're up and running. This morning we had a successful launch of the Teams-based classes. The data are still coming in and will be reported in Monday's Briefing, but for now, we are confident that we either have everyone connected, or we have a method for solving their connection difficulties. On Monday morning, we will launch our first full week of **EPSOnline**, with classes, advisory group meetings and individual check-in sessions with students. We will continue our daily Briefings and will attempt to provide more "on the ground" stories about what works, what doesn't, and we'll be sending surveys out to families at various points in the next 3 weeks to capture your good ideas as well.

Enjoy the weekend, and we'll see you at 8:00 AM on Monday, March 9.

EPSOnline

We have compiled all communications related to Eastside Prep's Remote Learning in one site: <Link and password to communications archive>. This archive of [EPSOnline](#) contains everything we send to families. If you missed a briefing, you will find it here. Every document we've sent as an attachment is also curated here. Check this site regularly to stay current with our progress.

Students should review their schedule to be sure they know when they need to sign in. Teachers have sent the invitations to their classes. Attendance will be taken for each class every day. In order to replicate the regular classroom experience, we are not recording classes.

Online Classes Begin Next Week!

*** MIDDLE BAND SCHEDULE**

In both the Middle and Upper Schools, students will meet via Teams with their advisory groups each Monday (11:05 AM to 11:50 AM for Upper School and 11:40 AM to 12:25 PM for Middle School). Advisors will also schedule one-to-one check-ins with each advisee on a weekly basis. For the time being, other middle band programming is being held open for office hours and other individual conversations. This work will enable us to keep tabs on how each student is managing the transition to remote learning. Thanks to all for participating in this valuable feedback circuit.

Microsoft Teams Application

While teams will operate inside of a web page, students will have a better experience if they download the desktop application. If they have not installed the desktop application, they can do so by clicking the download link in the bottom left of the teams webpage.

And then save and run the downloaded file.



All School Musical Auditions Update!

The All-School Musical is still on! We are making some adjustments in our audition process since we are all working remotely.

1. Students who are interested in auditioning or working on the backstage crew, please fill out this form to indicate interest: <form link>.
2. Join us for information sessions on March 12 at 3:45 PM for Upper School and March 13 at 3:45 PM for Middle School. Students need to fill out the form at the link above to be invited to that Teams session. The sessions will offer more information on how we will be conducting auditions digitally.
3. Once students fill out the interest form, they will also be invited to the All-School Musical canvas page and additional information about auditioning will be available there. The canvas page will provide access to the digital version of the script and music.

If you have any questions about the musical or auditions, please contact Production Coordinator, <name and email>.

Other Reminders

- Students will not meet via Teams during **Study Halls**. It is a good time to check in with individual teachers or classmates; however, we also encourage students to use that time to take a break from their screens if possible by getting outside, reading a book, creating some art, and so forth.
- Parents/guardians are requested to check in with their students for any technical concerns (mic not working, can't access Teams, no audio on video, etc.). Please email <tech help email> for assistance.
- Winter trimester is now closed; grades will be released on Thursday, March 12. If students have any concerns, please ask them to contact their advisor or teacher directly.
- Eastside Prep's regular Weekly Email to the community will be suspended while daily briefings are occurring.

Seen and Heard

[collection of images from our community using teams for test classes. Sharing their workspaces and pets with each other]